NESS DIGITAL ENGINEERING

TECHNICAL CERTIFICATION AND HIGHER EDUCATION – POLICY & PROCEDURE

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DOCUMENT RELEASE NOTICE

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REVISION HISTORY FOR NESS ACADEMY

Version Ref. (Released)	Release Date	Created/ Revised by	Reviewed by	Approved by	Description of the Revision
1.0	11-Oct-2018	Jyothi G.	Pranay M.	Narayanan Nair	Initial Release
1.1	11-Oct-2019	Gyan P.	Jyothi G.	Narayanan Nair	Reviewed the templates which are falling under the Frequency update dates.
1.2	10-Jul-2020	Gyan P.	Jyothi G.	Narayanan Nair	Revisited the document to check for any corrections. No changes are made.
1.3	1-Jun-2021	Gyan P. and Jyothi G.	Rajiv Dadi	Narayanan Nair	Added the Procedure guidelines to form a single “Policy & Procedure” document. Updated the technology focus areas based on 2021 needs.

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Section 1: Purpose

In keeping with our vision to become a global provider of innovative, and customer-centric digital transformation solutions, we encourage our employees to constantly upgrade their competencies and leverage their potential by providing them financial assistance. This document describes reimbursement policy to provide financial assistance to employees who wish to undertake any Certifications / Examinations in areas related to the Company's Business Interest.

Section 2: Scope

The scope of this document is to define the Technical Certification and Higher Education Policy applicable for all the personnel at Ness NDE.

Section 3: Definition

"Technical Certification and Higher Education Policy" will include Certifications in specific technology areas, based on practices' capability building, current project requirements, client requirements or aligned to future business growth.

Section 4: Entry Criteria - Eligibility and General Terms

1. Employee should have completed minimum 6 months of active service with the company at the time of application. (Exceptions are allowed at each Ness region to waiver this minimum tenure clause based on the "Business Justification" by the Department/Function Head)
2. The employee must commit to obtaining the certification within a stipulated time frame of the program.
3. All courses should be undertaken from credible, accredited, and approved institutes or certifying bodies. The certifying institute or agency should be mentioned in the request.
4. Employees may undertake more than one certification or program, subject to the total cost of such certifications not exceeding the eligibility defined below.
5. Maximum reimbursement amount eligibility for Certifications/Higher Education as per below table:

Ness Region	Certification Amount	Higher Education Amount	Currency
Canada	425	1000	Canadian Dollars
Kosice	300	700	Euro
India	25000	55,000	Indian Rupees
Romania	1250	3,000	RON
UK	275	600	Pounds
USA	350	800	US Dollars

6. Based on the approval process completion, the employee will be eligible for reimbursement of the following expenses after full completion of Certifications/Higher Education:

Sl no	Particulars	Covered	Remarks
1	Registration Fee	Yes	-
2	Course Fees	Yes	
3	Course Materials	Yes	Within the overall eligibility limits.
4	Library Fee	No	-
5	Examination Fee	Yes	-
6	Membership Fee	No	-
7	Renewal Fee	No	-

7. During the program (certification or higher education), employees must adhere to the Company's confidentiality policies. Participants should take explicit written approvals from the Center Head / Functional Head prior to sharing any company artifacts, client sensitive information, client names, software codes etc. Participants should also seek prior written approval before publishing any such information on social media or technical forum, such as GITHUB etc.

Section 5: Input

- Pre-approved certification List (ANNEXURE - 1)
- Approval from Reporting Manager/ Center HR Lead/ Function Head

Section 6: Program Categories and Entitlements

This Policy benefit will cover two categories of Certifications and Education Programs as defined below:

Category 1) Certifications driven by Business Needs and/or Client Requirements:

1. Global Learning and Development (L&D) will publish a list of pre-approved certifications (provided in Annexure-1) based on current and near future priorities of the company. This list will be reviewed and refreshed on periodic basis as defined in this policy.
2. The maximum limit of the reimbursement granted for certifications will be 80% of the total cost, per year, up to the maximum amount detailed below under Section 4.5 (Currently covering 100% reimbursement for AWS, MS Azure, Snowflake, Salesforce and GCP certifications only)
3. Agreement:
    - Agreement/Bond will be executed as per the discretion of the Department Head/Employee Manager based on the Business Need and must be in complete Compliance as per the regional laws of the concerned Ness center.
    - The concerned Department Head/Employee Manager will need to decide the following:
        i. Agreement Duration (in count of Months)
        ii. Agreement Amount (based on the cost of Certification amount)
        iii. Withholding Amount (e.g. Complete Agreement amount / Pro-rata basis)
    - Based on the discretion of the Department Head/Employee Manager, the employee will need to sign an agreement, to the effect that if the employee resigns from the company before completion of agreed months from the date of reimbursement, the applicable amount will need to be paid back to Ness by the employee.
    - This reimbursement may be executed by way of withholding that amount from the final settlement of the concerned employee as part of the exit process.
    - In case the company asks the employee to exit due to any reason, then the agreement withholding amount waiver will be considered.

Category 2) Higher Education Programs:

1. The selected Higher Education program must be relevant to one's professional career or based on the individual Career Development Plan.
2. For e.g., if an employee is a Software Developer and would like to pursue an MBA, the request will be approved only if it aligns to the employee's stated career plan at Ness. However, if the employee would like to do a post-graduation in IT/Software Development, from an accredited university, such request will be considered on merit.
3. The maximum limit of the reimbursement granted for Higher Education program will be 50% of the total cost of the complete Program up to the maximum amount detailed under Section 4.5
4. Agreement:
    - Agreement/Bond will be executed as per the discretion of the Department Head/Employee Manager based on the Business Need and must be in complete Compliance as per the regional laws of the concerned Ness center.

- The concerned Department Head/Employee Manager will need to decide the following:
    i. Agreement Duration (in count of Months)
    ii. Agreement Amount (based on the cost of Certification amount)
    iii. Withholding Amount (e.g. Complete Agreement amount / Pro-rata basis)
- Based on the discretion of the Department Head/Employee Manager, the employee will need to sign an agreement, to the effect that if the employee resigns from the company before completion of agreed months from the date of reimbursement, the applicable amount will need to be paid back to Ness by the employee.
- This reimbursement may be executed by way of withholding that amount from the final settlement of the concerned employee as part of the exit process.
- In case the company asks the employee to exit due to any reason, then the agreement withholding amount waiver will be considered.

Section 7: Procedure

1. **Application Process**:
    - The details of the program should be discussed with the reporting Manager as well as with Center HR Lead and initiated through LMS before commencing the certification program.
    - The reporting manager will review the employee request against eligibility criteria and have discussions with Center Head/Function head, and accordingly approve the employee request in the LMS tool.
2. **Enrollment Process in LMS tool**:
    Please refer the step-by-step process guidelines available from Page 12 onwards of this document to see the following actions needed to be undertaken to complete the enrollment and reimbursement process:
    - Employee Application actions
    - Manager Approval actions
3. **Administration of Reimbursement Amount:**
    - On completion of the program, the employee should update the certification or any other program details in LMS and upload the soft copy of the certificate on LMS for future reference.
    - The employee will apply for reimbursement through the normal reimbursement process, attaching a copy of the course completion certificate and proof of all payments made, and get the request approved by reporting manager. Reimbursement will not be done in parts for semesters but will be done at the end of the entire course on production of the final certificate.
    - All payments will be made as reimbursement and no advance payments will be done.

Section 8: Measurement Criteria

Tracking of completed Certification/Higher Education requests at each Ness region.

- Global NDE Region data collation in the Certificate Reimbursement Tracker on Quarterly basis.
- Reporting the completed Certification count to HR and Delivery management.

Section 9: Roles and Responsibilities

Roles	Responsibilities
Employee	Request for the program, with justification in the LMS tool. Get approval in LMS from EDC Manager/Functional Head/Center Head before commencing the certification or program.

Reporting Manager / EDC Manager / Functional Head and Center Head	Ensure that the certification/course is in line with the company's business requirements and employee's eligibility criteria and career development.
Center HR Lead/ Ness Academy	Review eligibility along with EDC Manager / Functional Manager and Center Head. Review the list of pre-approved Certifications on annual basis (additionally on any timeline based on unforeseen Business critical need) with key stakeholders, consolidate list of certified employees and ensure updating of LMS / internal records.

Section 10: Executive Owner

The Functional/Department Heads shall be responsible for implementing and executing the policy mentioned in this document. The execution shall be coordinated and reviewed by the Ness Academy department.

Section 11: Output

- Final Completion Certificate
- Employee updating and closing the process in LMS

Section 12: Exit Criteria

- FAM Reimbursement Ticket or Reimbursement Request based on the local process of the concerned Ness Region
- Certificate Reimbursement Tracker

Section 13: Verification and Validation Criteria

- Internal audits verify the policy followed for the process improvement
- Annual check on various metrics is tracked

Section 14: Glossary

EDC	Extended Development Center
HR	Human Resources
L&D (Ness Academy)	Learning & Development
LMS	Learning Management System
NDE	Ness Digital Engineering
CDP	Career Development Plan
OPG	Organizational Processes Group

Section 15: Standard/Model Reference

Control	Major Clause	Name	KPA
9001:2015	7.2	Competence	Organizational Training
27001:2013	A.7.2.2	Information security awareness, education and training	Organizational Training

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Section 16: Maintenance & Update Trigger

This policy will be reviewed annually as well as any changes in the organization vision & mission. The Ness Academy team will deal with any other aspect not expressly covered in the document appropriately from time to time.

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ANNEXURE - 1

List of Pre-Approved Certifications

Note**: Currently covering 100% reimbursement for AWS, MS Azure, Snowflake, Salesforce and GCP certifications only. (for other Certifications, reimbursement amount is as per the policy)

Domain / Board	Certification Level
Agile and Scrum Boards	Scrum.org Certifications
	Scrum Alliance Certifications
	Safe Agilist Certifications
	PMI Certifications
	ICAgile Certifications
	DevOps Institute
Amazon Web Services (AWS)**	AWS Fundamentals
	AWS Associate
	AWS Professional
	AWS Specialty
Cloud Native Computing Foundation (CNCF)	Certified Kubernetes Administrator (CKA)
	Certified Kubernetes Application Developer (CKAD)
Cloudera	CCP Data Engineer
Databricks	Databricks Certified Developer
Docker	Docker Certified Associate
Google Cloud (GCP)**	User Certification
	Professional Certification
	Associate Certification
Horton Works	The Hortonworks Certified Associates (HCA) Certification
	The HDP Certified Developer Big Data Hadoop Certification
Microsoft	MCSA Machine Learning
	Analyzing and Visualizing Data with Microsoft Power BI
Microsoft Azure**	Microsoft Azure Fundamentals
	Microsoft Azure Expert
	Microsoft Azure Associate
	Microsoft Azure Specialty
MuleSoft	MuleSoft Certified Developer
	MuleSoft Certified Architect
Pega	Certified System Architect (CSA)
	Certified Senior System Architect (CLSA)
	Certified Lead System Architect (CLSA)
	Certified Robotics System Architect (CRSA)
	Certified Pega Business Architect (CPBA)
QA Testing Boards	ISTQB Certifications
	iSAQB Certifications

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	QAI Certifications
SalesForce.com**	Salesforce Administrator
	Salesforce Developer
	Salesforce Technical Architect
	Salesforce Marketer
	Salesforce Consultant
Snowflake**	SnowPro Core Certification
	SnowPro Advanced Certification
Tableau	Tableau Desktop Certified Professional
	Tableau Server Certified Professional

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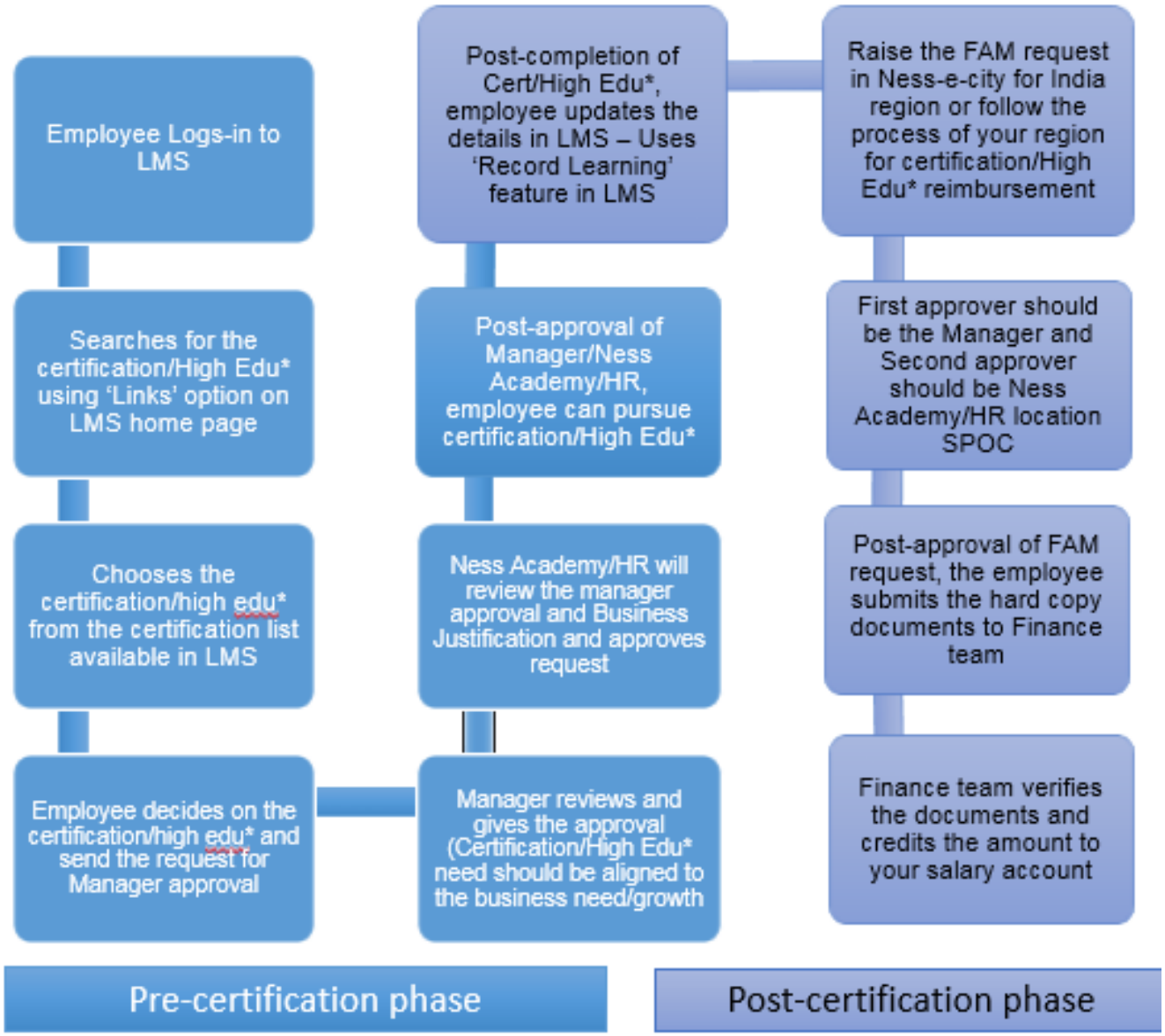
Enrollment and Reimbursement Procedure Guidelines for Employees and Managers

High Level Process Flow



CONTENTS

Step-by-step process for each Stage is explained in the subsequent pages of this document

Page No.	Stage	Description	Via (Tool)	Action Required by
Page 12	**Stage 1:** Pre-Certification	Certification/Higher Education Program enrollment by Employee	LMS	Employee
Page 16	**Stage 2:** Manager Approval	Employee's Certification/Higher Education Request Approval on LMS	LMS	Employee's Direct Manager
Page 19	**Stage 3:** Post-Certification	Uploading Certification/Higher Education completion details and document on LMS	LMS	Employee
Page 23	**Stage 4:** Reimbursement Claim	Final claim of reimbursement amount by providing the required supporting evidences	Ness-E-City FAM ticket Or HR Process of the local Ness region	i. Employee --> ii. Employee's Direct Manager --> iii. Location Ness Academy/ HR SPOC

➢ For Employees - LMS Request Steps

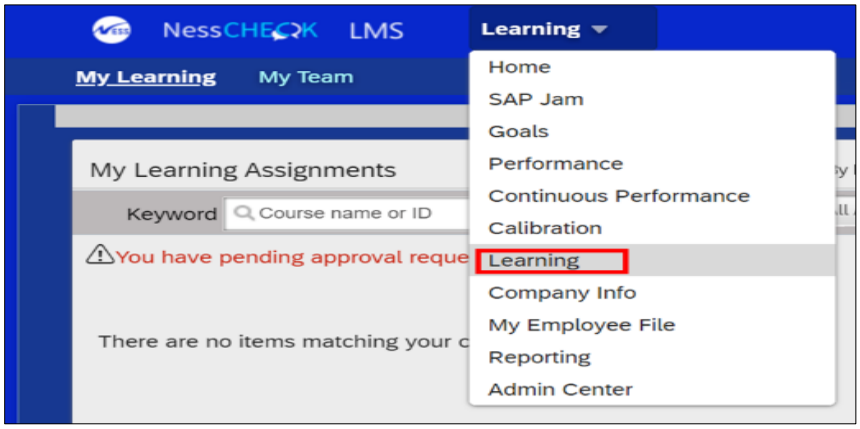
Stage 1: Pre-Certification –

Certification/Higher Education Program enrollment by Employee

- **Step 1** - Login to LMS from NessSpace ⟶ Tools & Apps ⟶ LMS

  Or Ness-E-city portal

- **Step 2** - Select 'Learning' from the drop down on LMS home page.



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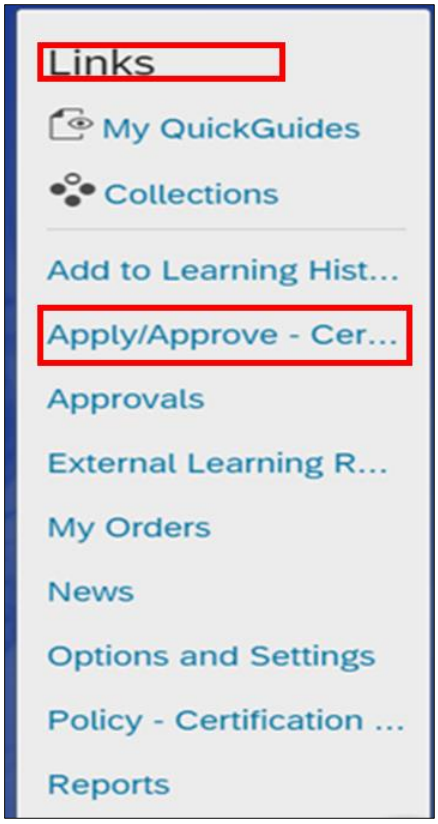
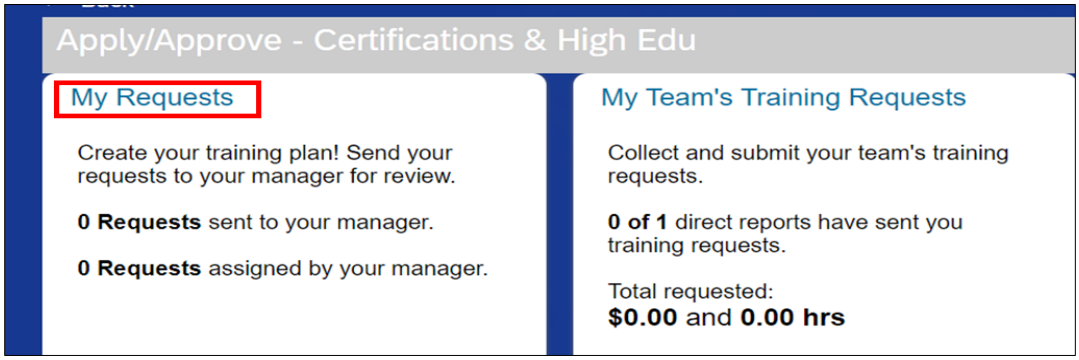
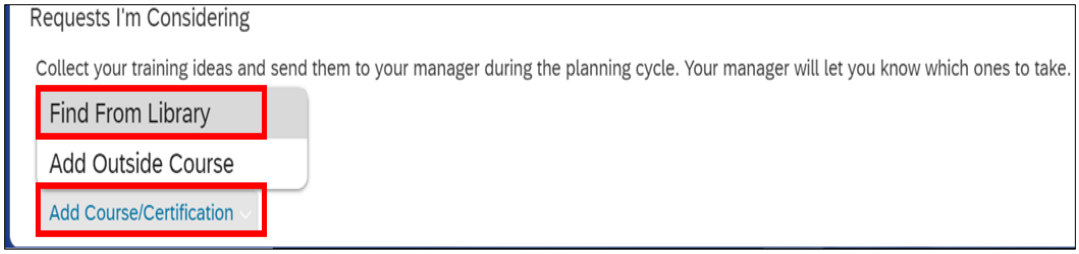
- **Step 3** - Click 'Apply/Approve Certifications/High Edu' under 'Links' of Learning page.



- **Step 4 -** Click on 'My Requests'



- **Step 5 -** Click 'Add Course/Course' & select 'Find From Library' from drop down list.



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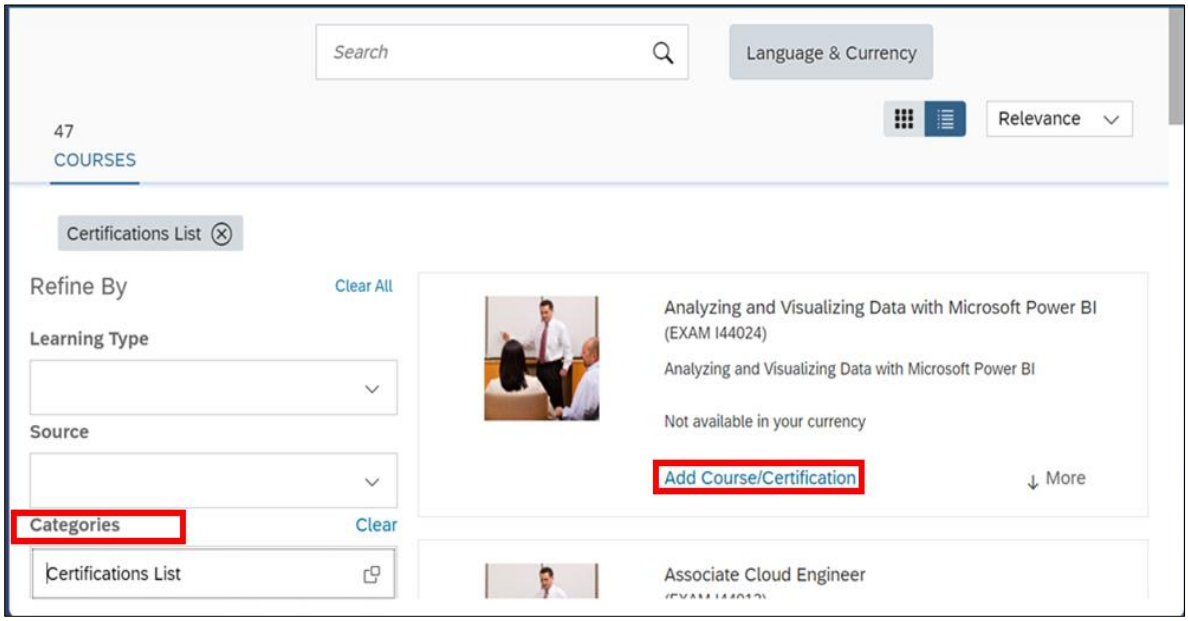
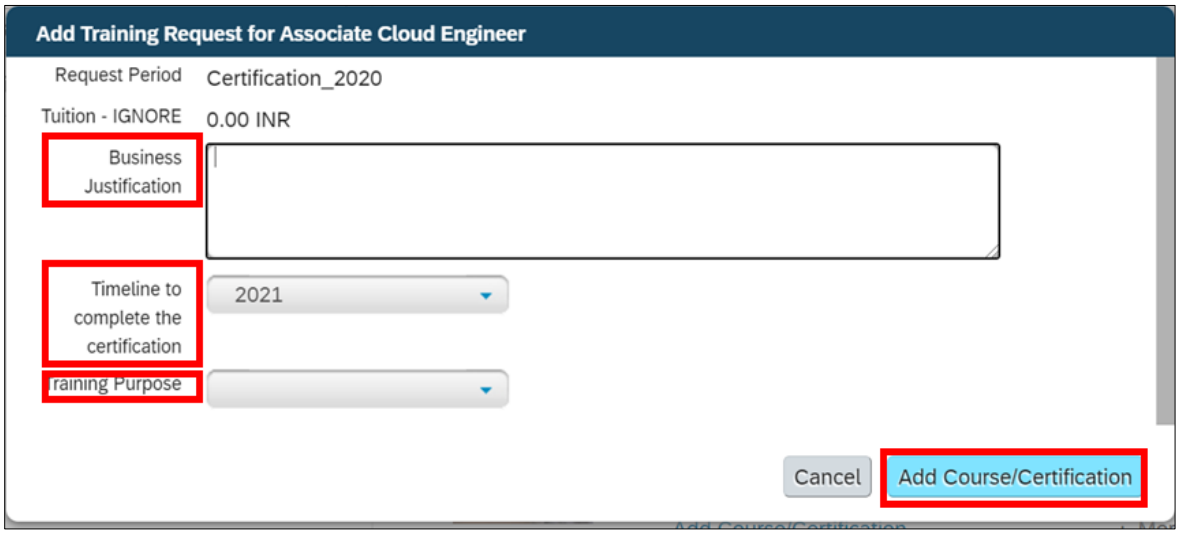
- **Step 6**
  a) Select 'Certifications List' under 'Categories' then on the right-hand side the list of certifications will appear.
  b) Choose the **Certification/High Edu** that you would like to pursue. Click on 'Add Course/Certification'.



- **Step 7 -** Provide **all** the details in the window as below. After filling the details, click on 'Add Course/Certification'.
  a) Business Justification – Provide relevant Business Justification.
  b) Timeline to complete the certification - Select the timeline from dropdown list by when you plan to complete the certification.
  c) Training Purpose – Select 'Business Need' or 'Career Growth' from drop down



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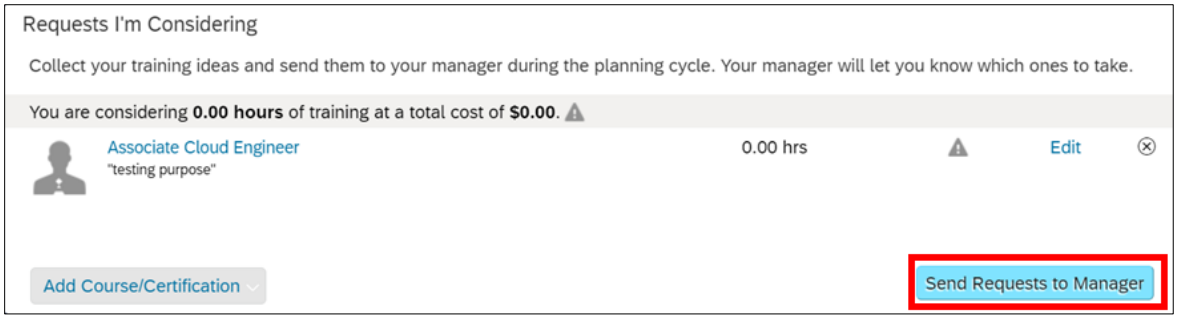
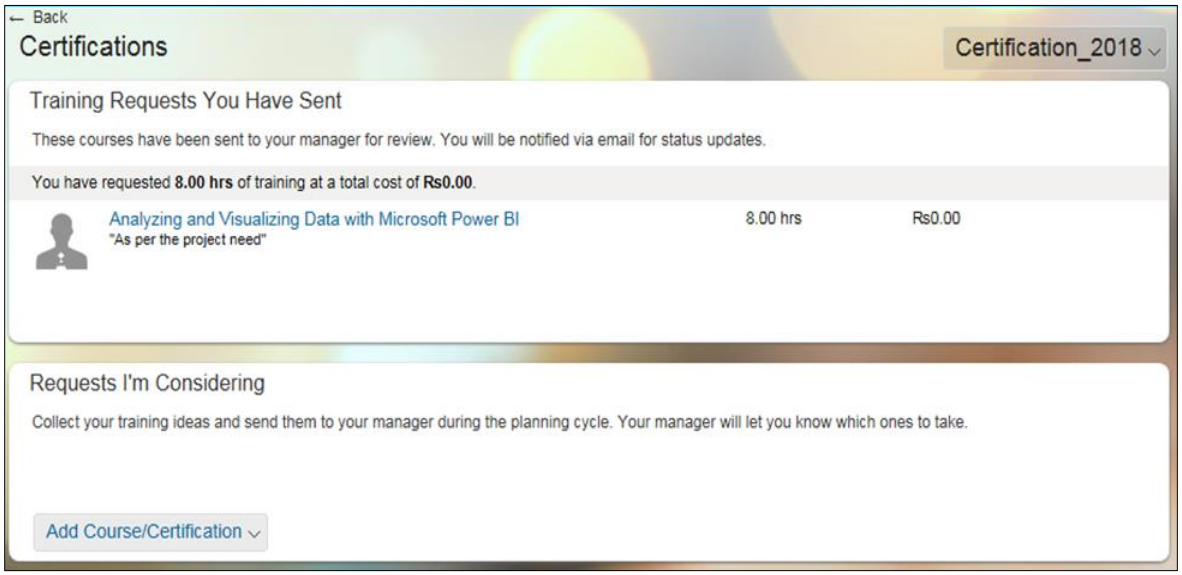
- **Step 8 -** On subsequent page, click on 'Send requests to manager'.



Next Steps:

- Your manager will be notified in LMS about your Certification/Higher Education request.
- After your manager approval (as per Stage-2 steps), Ness Academy / HR would review and approve your request.
- **Post receiving the approval notification, you can pursue the selected Certification/Higher Education program.**
- **Post Program Completion, please proceed with steps shown under Stage 3 segment**



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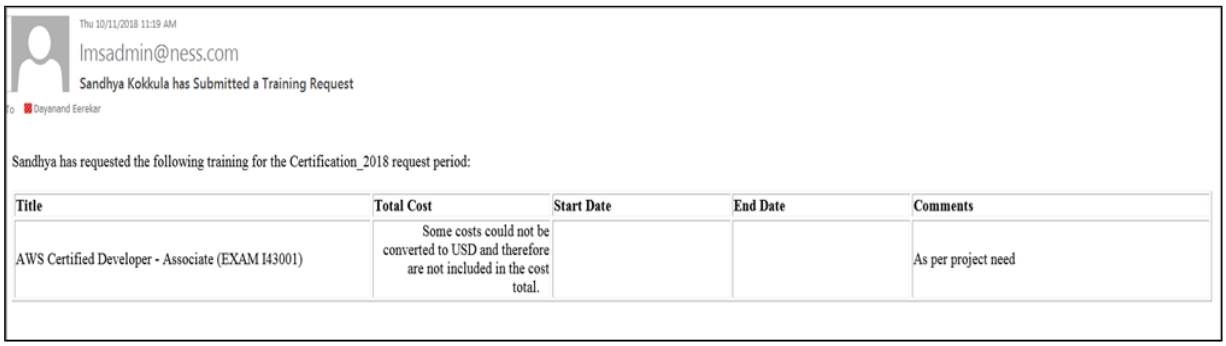
➢ For Managers - LMS Request Approval Steps

Stage 2: Manager Approval –

Employee's Certification/Higher Education Request Approval on LMS

- **Step 1 –** Once employee sends request to manager, Manager will receive an email notification from LMS. Below is the snapshot of the notification.



Thu 10/11/2018 11:19 AM

lmsadmin@ness.com

Sandhya Kokkula has Submitted a Training Request

To Dayanand Eerekar

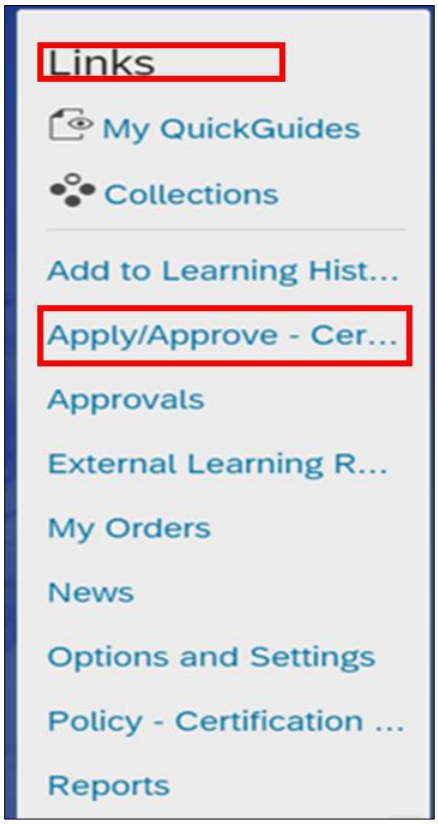
Sandhya has requested the following training for the Certification_2018 request period:

Title	Total Cost	Start Date	End Date	Comments
AWS Certified Developer - Associate (EXAM I43001)	Some costs could not be converted to USD and therefore are not included in the cost total.			As per project need

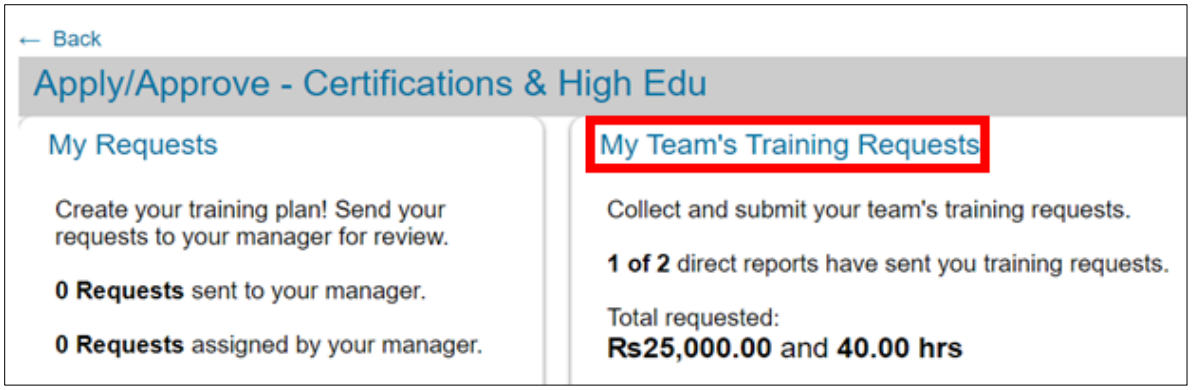
- **Step 2** - Login to LMS from NessSpace → Tools & Apps → LMS

  Or Ness-E-city portal

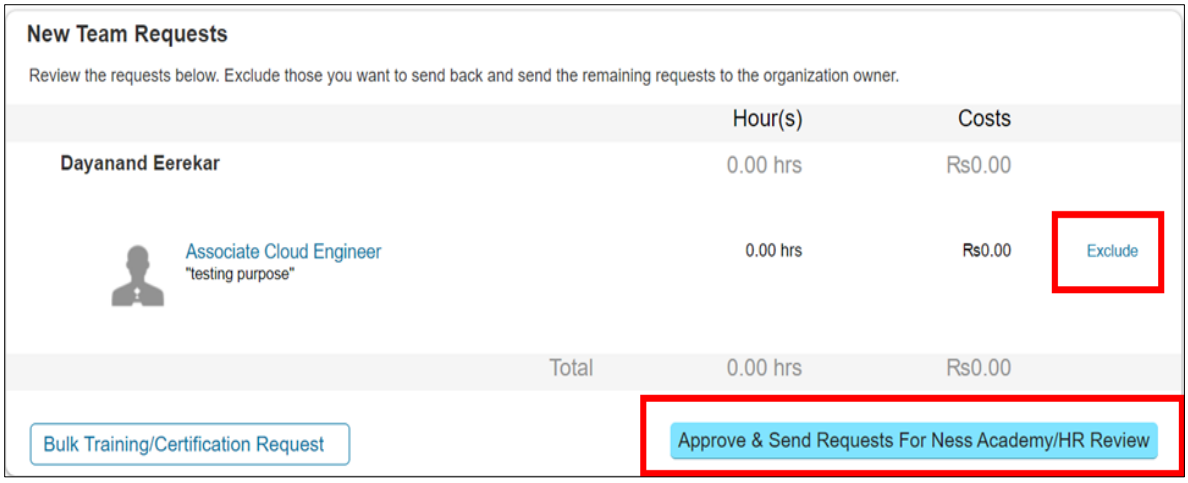
- **Step 3 -** Click on 'Apply - Certifications/High Edu' under 'Links' of LMS landing page.



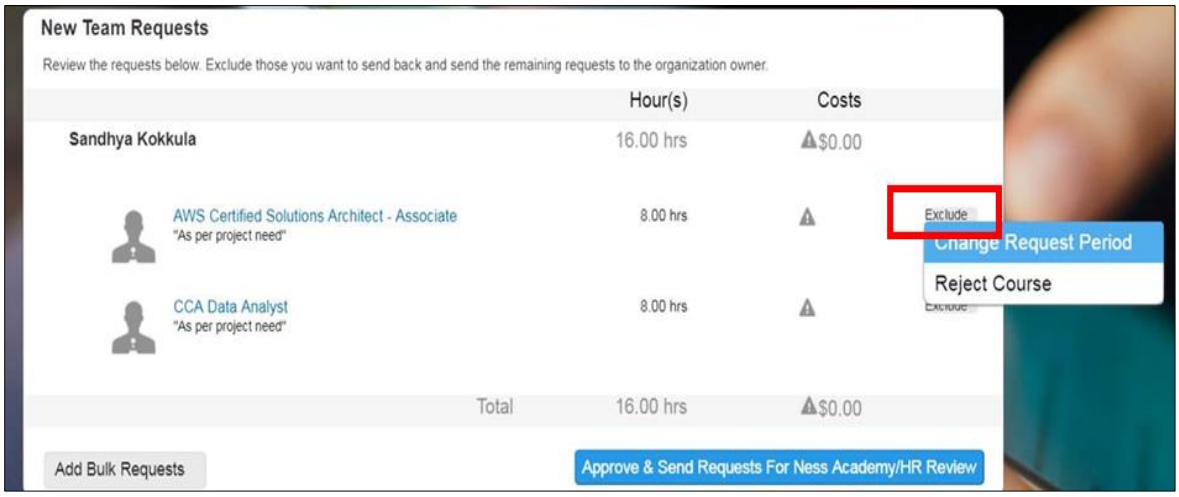
- **Step 4** - Click on 'My Team's Training Requests'.



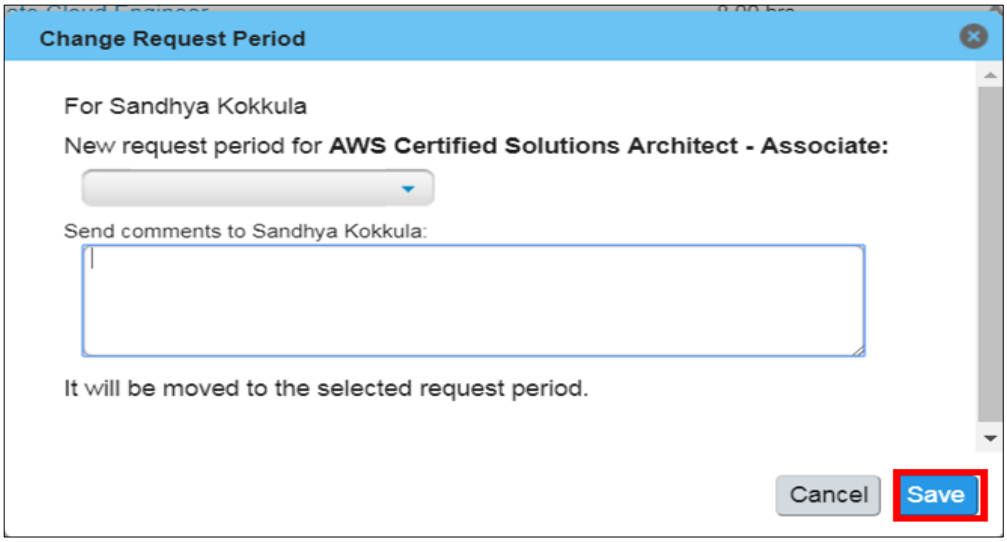
- **Step 5** – Here you will find the certifications requests from your team. Manager can either approve the request by clicking on 'Approve & Send Requests for Ness Academy/HR Review' or 'Exclude' button.



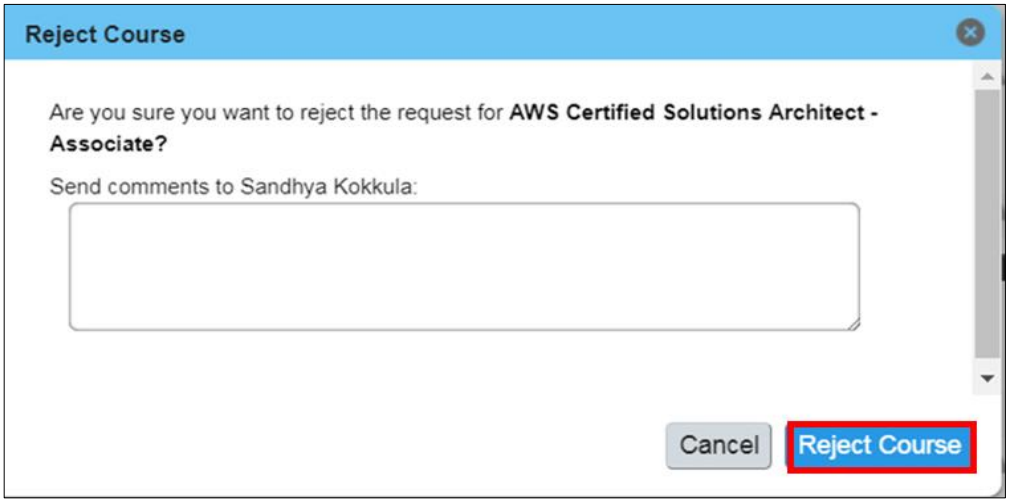
- **Step 6 -** Manager can click on '**Exclude'** for choosing 'Change Request Period' or 'Reject Course'.



- **Step 7 -** Select the period from Drop down and mention the comments. Click on 'Save'.



- **Step 8 -** Mention the comments and click on 'Reject Course'.



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➢ For Employees - LMS Document Upload Steps

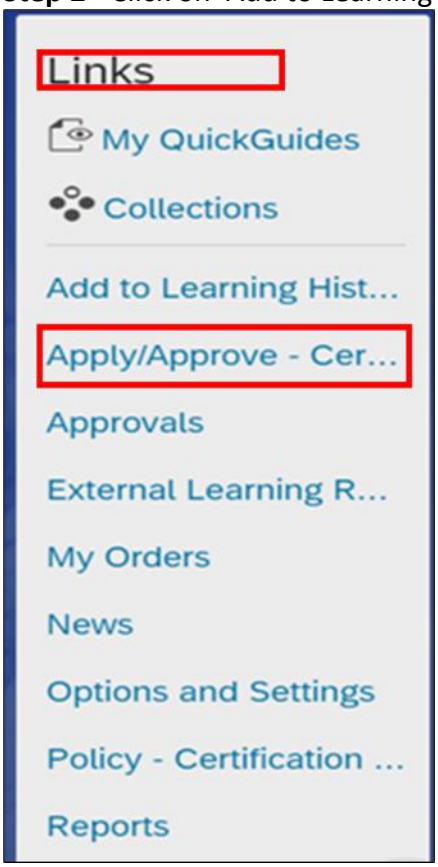
Stage 3: Post-Certification –

Uploading Certification/Higher Education completion details and document on LMS

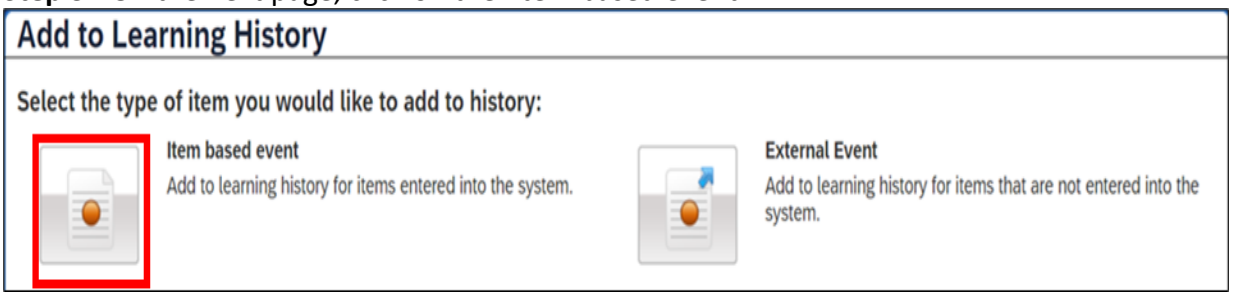
- **Step 1** - Login to LMS from NessSpace → Tools & Apps → LMS

  Or Ness-E-city portal

- **Step 2 -** Click on 'Add to Learning History' under Links on LMS landing page.



- **Step 3 -** On the next page, click on the 'Item based event'



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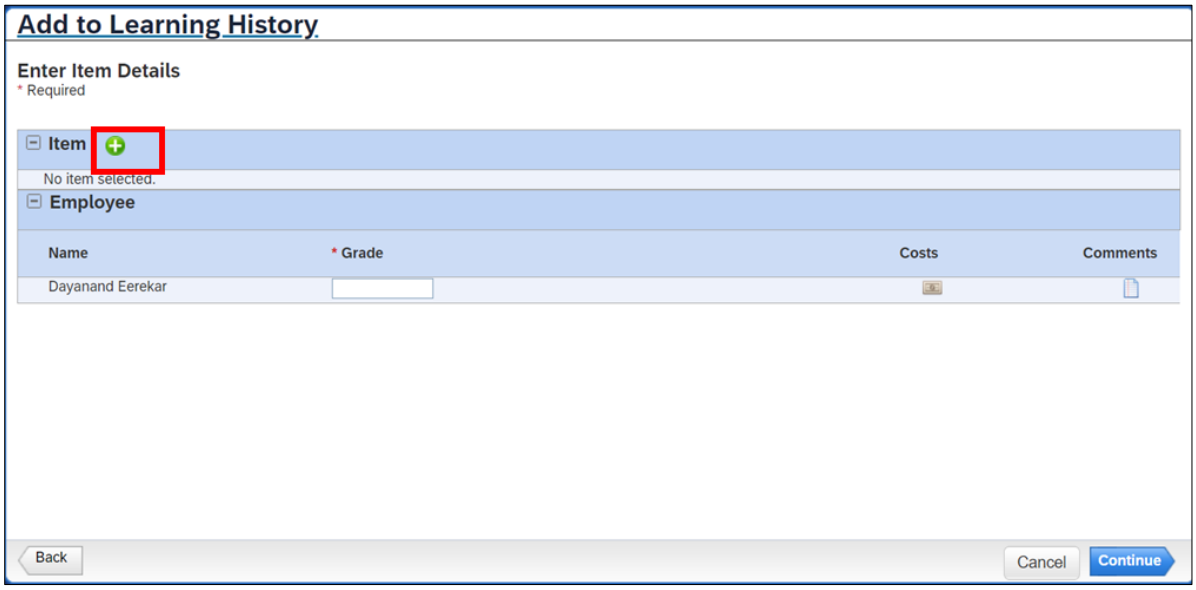
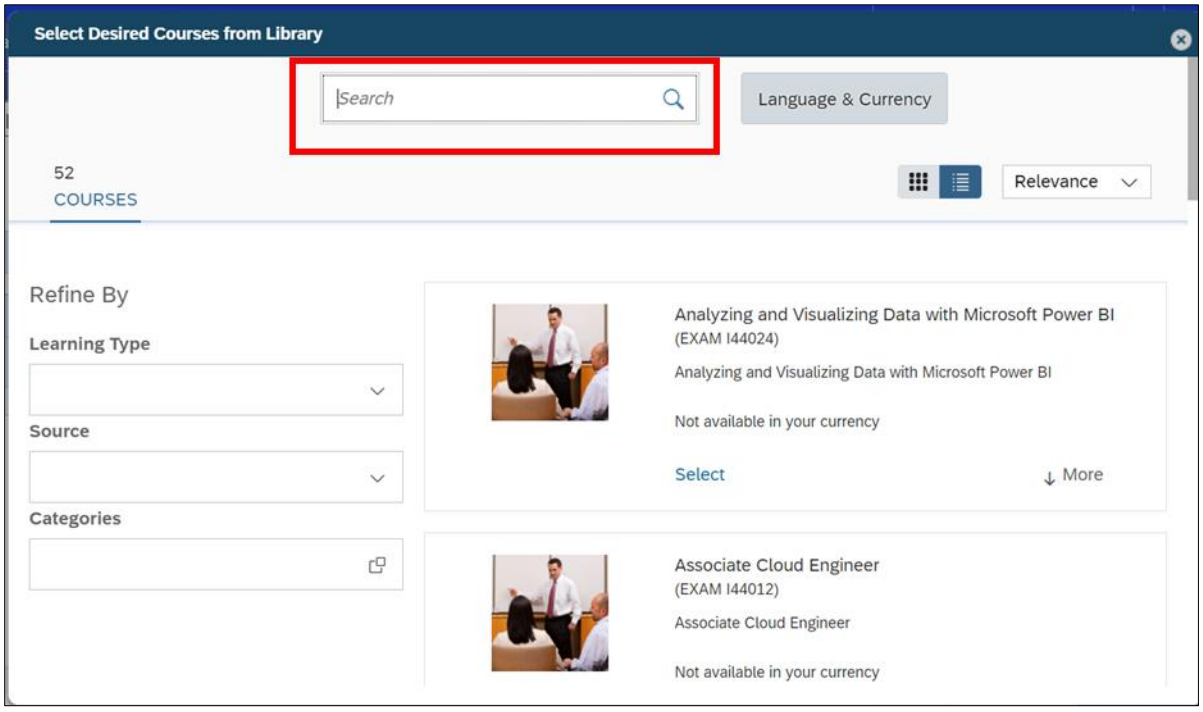
- **Step 4 -** Click on '**+**' button to add the certification name



- **Step 5 -** Type the key word of the certification in the search box and press enter



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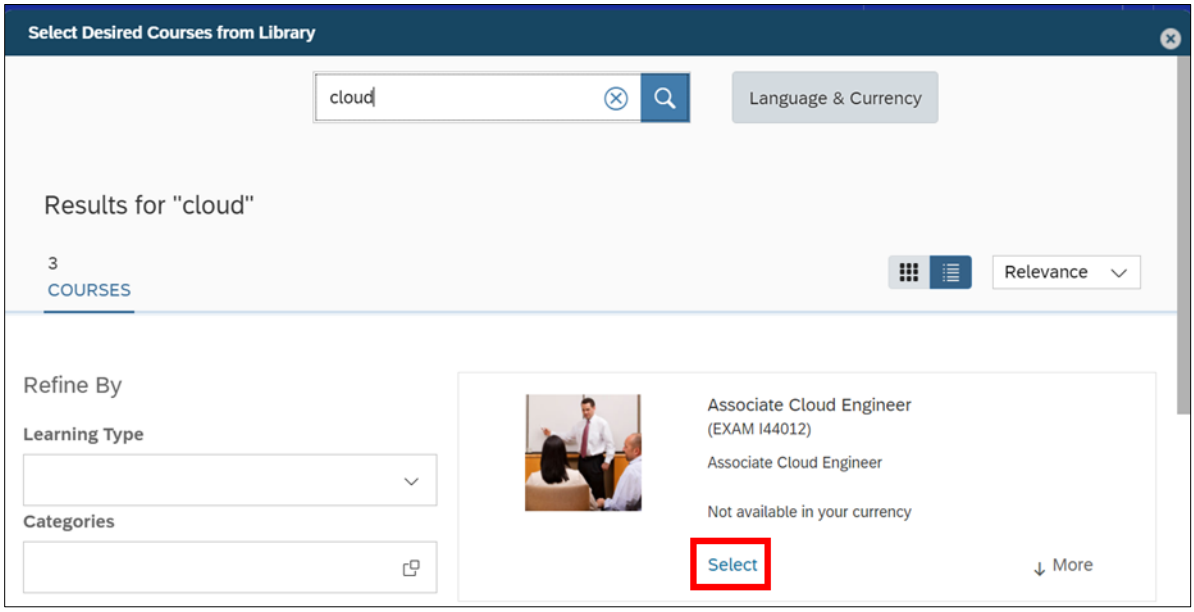
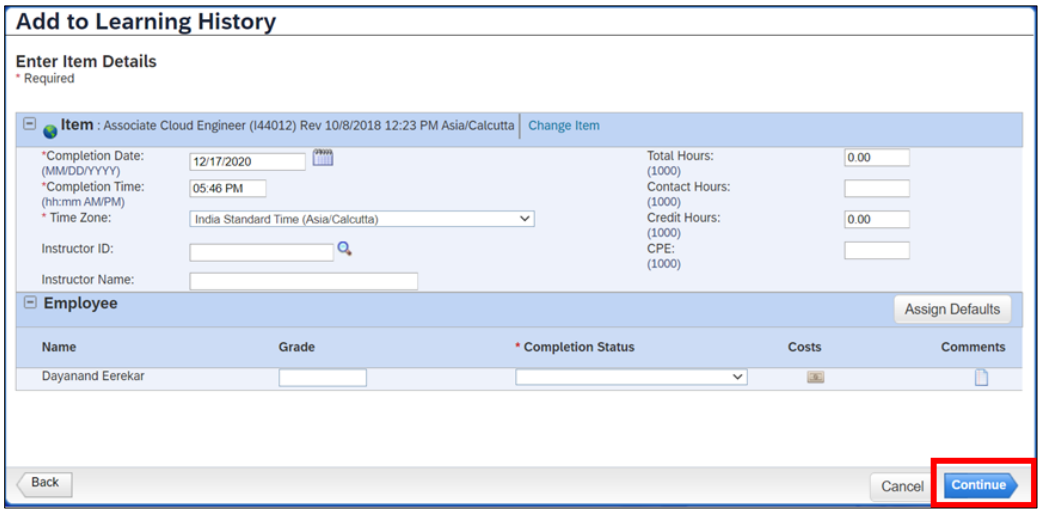
- **Step 6 -** Click on **'**Select' the certification that you have completed and click on 'Next'



- **Step 7** - Fill the other details related to certificate and click on 'Continue'.
  - Completion Date: **Mention** the date on which you cleared the exam/certification
  - Completion Time: **Mention** the time
  - Time Zone: **Select** India Standard Time (Select your time zone)
  - Instructor ID: **Ignore**
  - Instructor Name: **Mention** the certificate organization name (Example: Sun Java/Oracle/SAP)
  - Total Hours: **Mention** the training hours, if you have attended any training.
  - Contact Hours: **Ignore**
  - Credit Hours: **Same as 'Total Hours'**
  - CPE: Ignore
  - Grade: Percentage that you **secured**
  - **Completion Status: Select 'Exam_Pass (Exam Pass) – For Credit'**



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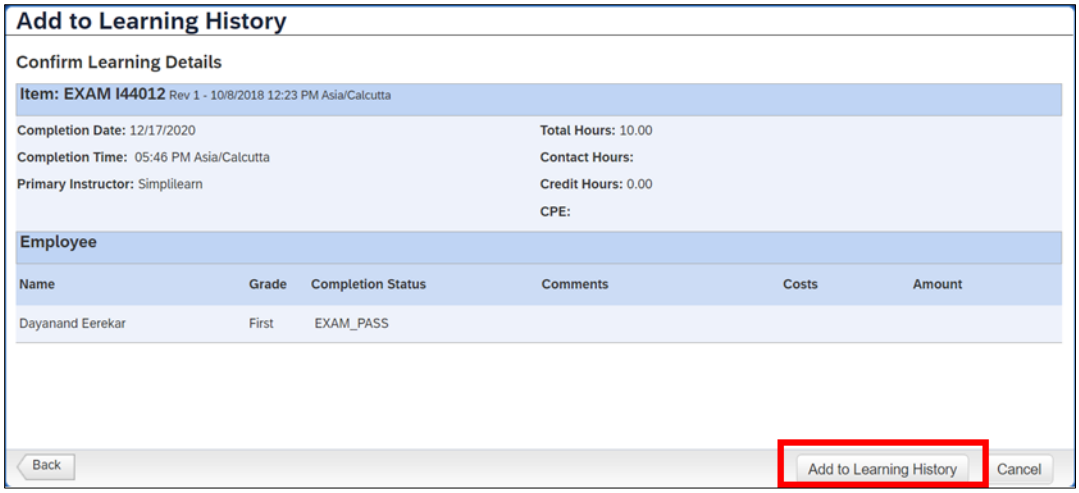
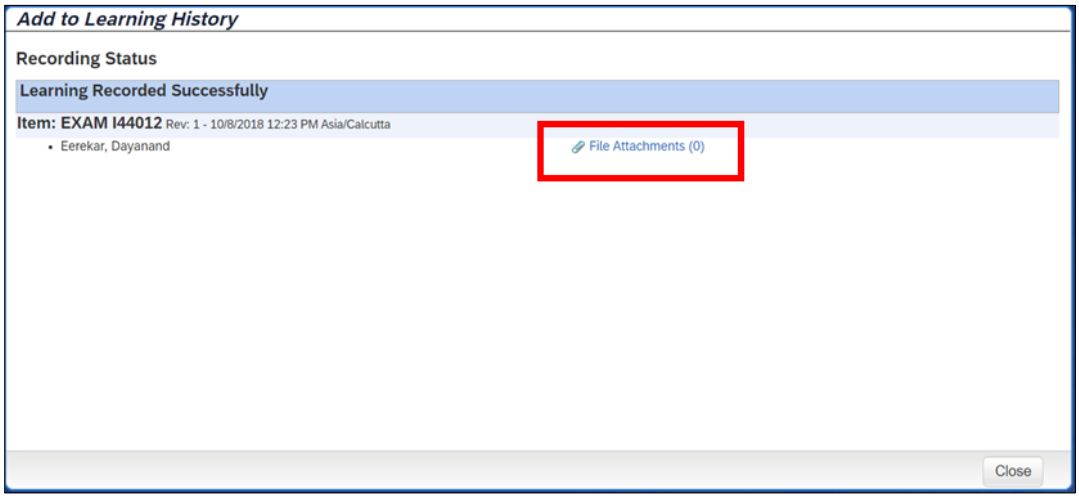
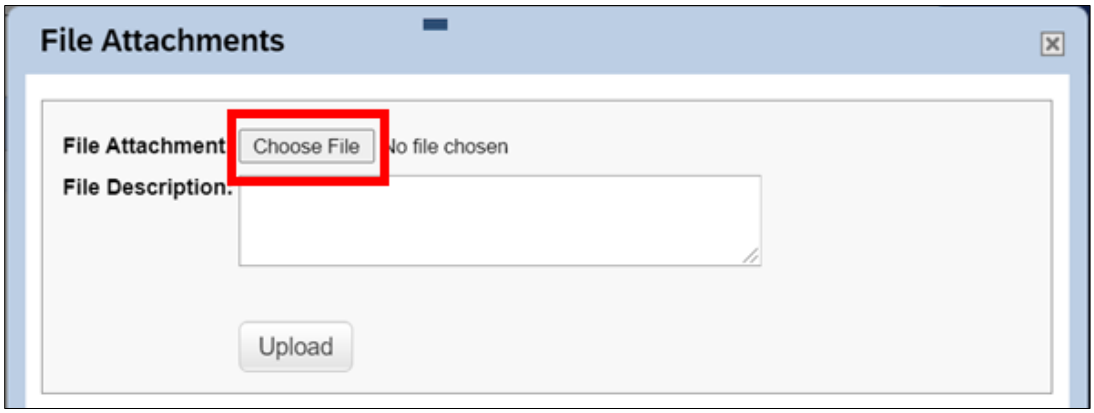
- **Step 8 -** Click on 'Add to Learning History'



- **Step 9 -** Click on 'File Attachment' to upload the 'Completion Certificate'



- **Step 10 -** Click on 'Choose File' to upload the 'Completion Certificate' and provide the description of the certificate like certification body name…etc



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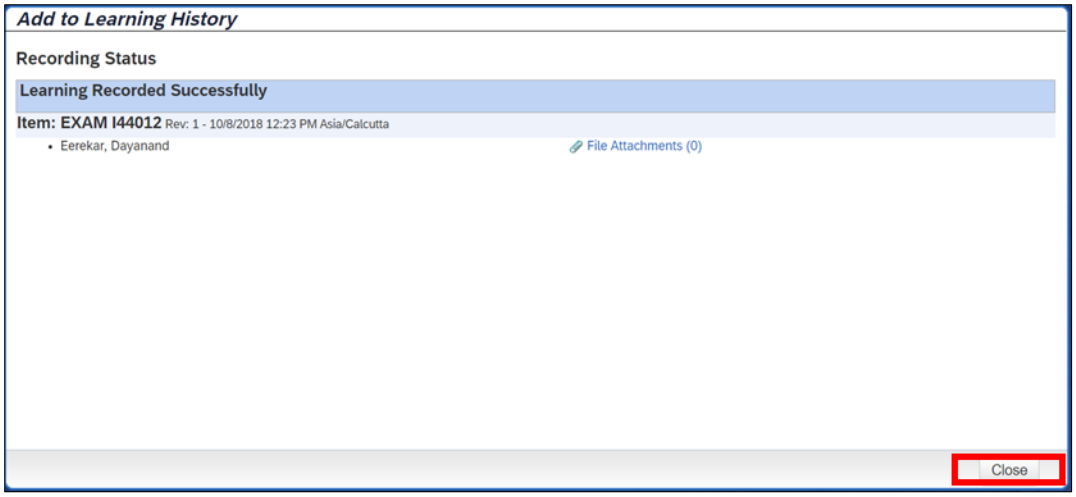
- **Step 11 -** After uploading the certificate, click on 'Close' button.



➢ For Employees – Reimbursement Claim

Stage 4: Reimbursement Claim –

Final claim of reimbursement amount by providing the required supporting evidences

- After uploading the certification details on LMS, you can apply for reimbursement request by raising FAM ticket in Ness-e-City for India region (under sub request of "Tech. Certification and Higher Edu. Policy") or follow the process of your region-specific certification reimbursement process.
- Guidelines to raise FAM ticket in Ness-e-City for India region (under sub request of "Tech. Certification and Higher Edu. Policy")
  - First approver should be the Direct Manager.
  - Second approver should be the Ness Academy Location representative/HR.
- Provide complete description in the ticket about what exactly are you applying this ticket for. This is required for the ease of understanding for the Finance department.
- Input the exact total amount spent.
- In the FAM ticket, you need to upload a Zip file attachment which must include the **Final Completion Certificate** and **Proof of Payment** made in Employee's name.
- Post verification, Finance team will credit the amount to your Salary account.

-- End of Document --